Two nationalist papers, the Calcutta-based *Bande Mataram* edited by Aurobindo Ghosh and the Pune-based *Mahratta* edited by Tilak, mentioned the price of the ships.[56] While *Mahratta* gave a total figure of £30,000 (Rs 4,50,000), *Bande Mataram* provided a break-up: the *Lawoe* was bought for Rs 1,50,000, while the *Gallia* cost Rs 2,40,000 giving a total of Rs 3,90,000. *Bande Mataram* also reported the purchase of two steam launches, of which one cost Rs 30,000. According to S. Vedamurthi Mudaliar, the *Gallia* was easily worth Rs 2,40,000 (£16,000); he quoted one Mr Barry, a broker, exclaiming in astonishment that he had earlier made an offer of Rs 3,00,000 for the same ship.[57] By the time it reached Bombay, it had cost Rs 3,00,000 according to the *Bande Mataram*.[58] According to SSNCo's Madras agent, W. Srinivasan, the *Gallia* cost Rs 3,50,000 while the *Lawoe* was bought for Rs 3,00,000; both had already arrived at Bombay and were to reach Tuticorin on 11 April and Madras on 21 April 1907.[59] It is difficult to reconcile these conflicting figures. The official figures given in an undated prospectus (issued probably in early–mid 1907) were Rs 2,40,00 for the *Gallia*, Rs 1,50,000 for the *Lawoe* and Rs 30,000 for the steam launch *Miranda*.

Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co. acted as brokers in purchasing this steamer, though their commission remained unpaid even until 1908.[60]

One will never know if the inexperienced SSNCo was short-changed or if they had struck an excellent deal. The troubles that the steamers ran into later which disrupted the day-to-day business of SSNCo, led to many wagging tongues.

Unlike the prices, there are only minor variations in the reports about the dimensions of the steamers in the many contemporary newspapers. Luckily, we have information from more authoritative sources. Two internationally reputed classification societies, the British Lloyd's Register of Shipping, and the French Bureau Veritas provide this information.[61] The primary function of classification societies was to carry out surveys of ships even as they were being built. This monitoring was to maintain standards of ship construction and upkeep considering that shipping was an international